

managers pick the stocks and bonds that I own, and I get a dividend and/or interest check every month. It makes me feel warm and fuzzy when I see that cash coming in. You don't have to buy O'Leary Funds to acquire these benefits; there are many other good mutual funds available, run by terrific managers who know how to preserve and grow capital. What matters most is performance. A good investment advisor knows how to analyze mutual fund composition and performance and will help you make sound fund selections.

So, now that you know the secret of sustainable investing, you have to decide whether you are prepared to execute these strategies yourself or use the services of an investment advisor. The cold hard truth is that most people are not good at managing their own money. They lack the skill, discipline or time to get the job done. If you fall into this group, and most people do, you need to work with an advisor.

SIX RULES FOR FINDING A GOOD FINANCIAL ADVISOR

Here are six rules that I know will help you find a good advisor.

- 1. Be prepared to meet and interview a lot of candidates.** When it comes to choosing an investment advisor, don't rush. People who inherit large sums of money sometimes feel compelled to invest it all right away. If this happens to you (and I hope it does!), slow down. Starting a relationship with an advisor is like getting married: you want to think it through. Meet with at least five advisors, preferably from different firms, before you make your decision. Ask your friends for recommendations. Don't be afraid to call advisors; trust me when I say they can't wait to hear from you! Look for someone you feel comfortable with, who has a good track record of preserving capital and is willing to work within the guidelines you provide.
- 2. Do a background check.** Don't be embarrassed to check out your advisor's credentials. Remember, it's *your* money we are talking about here. Going online makes it easy, since almost all